Rhythm That Keeps Moving

Subdivision, dotted rhythms, compound time, triplets and syncopation.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Keep the small beats even
2. Dotted rhythms and ties across the beat
3. Two and three large beats
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5. Feel the beat when the melody shifts
6. Silent Night: two large beats
7. Holy, Holy, Holy: dotted precision
8. Blessed Assurance
9. Silent Night

1. Keep the small beats even

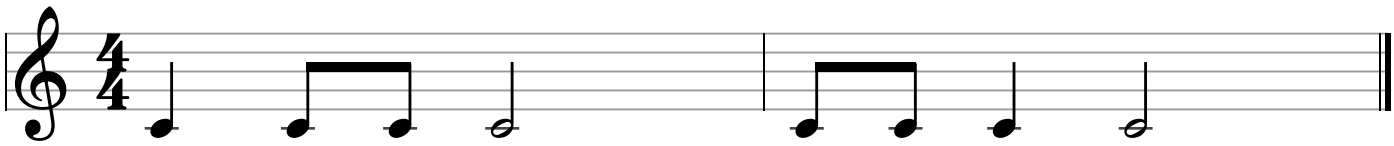
Use a reliable subdivision beneath changing rhythms.

Keep the small beats even

Count a steady stream of eighth-note subdivisions: 1-and-2-and-3-and-4-and. The spoken counting stays even when the hands hold longer notes. Start on one pitch so your attention can stay on time. In Flow, begin slowly; the app checks note starts, while you check the spaces between them.

Practise · One-key rhythm

Count the eighth-note stream through every longer note.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Rhythm against a bass

Keep the left hand steady while the melody subdivides.

Listen and check

Tap the rhythm away from the piano, then play it. If the rhythm changes when pitches are added, return to the single-note version.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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2. Dotted rhythms and ties across the beat

Keep counting when a note begins between beats.

Dotted rhythms and ties across the beat

A dotted quarter lasts three eighth-note subdivisions. Its following eighth belongs on the and of beat 2, not on beat 2 itself. A tie joins the same pitch and asks for one attack with a longer hold. Count beneath the tie so the next note arrives in the right place.

Practise · Long-short accuracy

Say 1-and-2-and; the short note lands on the final and.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A tie crosses beat two

Do not strike the tied E twice.

Listen and check

Listen for the short note arriving too early. Clap the subdivision while someone else counts the main beats, or use a slow metronome.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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3. Two and three large beats
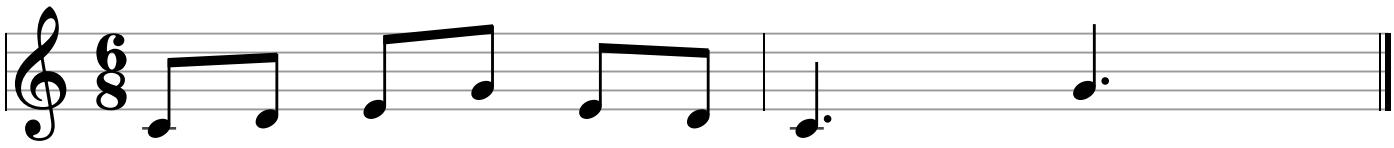
Feel 6/8 and 9/8 as groups of three eighths.

Two and three large beats

In 6/8, feel two large beats: ONE-two-three FOUR-five-six. In 9/8, feel three: ONE-two-three FOUR-five-six SEVEN-eight-nine. The dotted quarter is the large beat. Begin by counting all the eighths, then lighten the middle subdivisions. Do not make 6/8 sound like three pairs.

Practise · Two large beats

Lean gently on 1 and 4.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Three large beats

Feel three groups of three, not an uneven long bar.

Listen and check

Can you sway or tap only the large beats while playing? In Blessed Assurance, prepare the pickup before the first full group.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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4. Three notes in the space of two

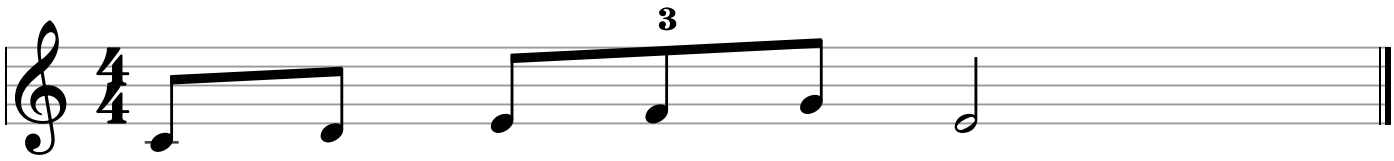
Distinguish triplets from ordinary eighth notes.

Three notes in the space of two

An eighth-note triplet divides one quarter-note beat into three equal parts. The bracket marked 3 means the three eighth-shaped notes share one beat. Say tri-po-let evenly while tapping quarters. Ordinary eighths divide that same beat into two. Keep the large beat unchanged when switching between them.

Practise · Two then three

First two eighths, then three triplet eighths on the next beat.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Triplets over quarters

Play three even right-hand notes against each left-hand quarter.

Listen and check

Listen for the middle triplet note being squeezed. Repeat on a single key, then restore the pitches while the beat stays even.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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5. Feel the beat when the melody shifts

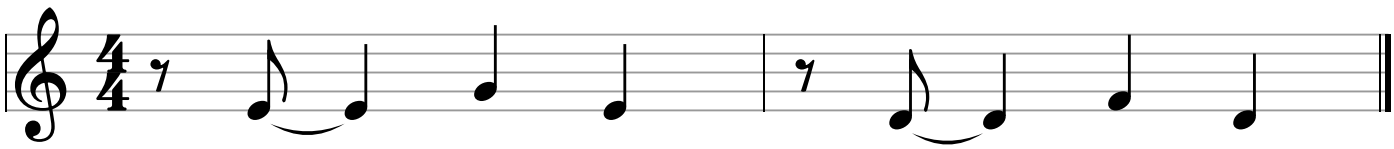
Let an offbeat note continue across a strong beat.

Feel the beat when the melody shifts

Syncopation places emphasis where you do not expect it. Here an eighth-note pickup within the bar is tied across the next beat. Keep the left hand on the beat so the right hand can lean away from it. Start by tapping; do not add accents by striking harshly.

Practise · An offbeat held across the beat

Count aloud. The tied note is one sound.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A steady anchor

Left quarters stay steady beneath the right-hand syncopation.

Listen and check

Could a listener tap the main beat from your accompaniment? Keep this as a rhythm variation exercise; do not change a hymn rhythm unless the arrangement asks for it.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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6. Silent Night: two large beats

Count six eighths first, then feel two groups of three. Keep the accompaniment under the melody.

What to listen for

Count six eighths first, then feel two groups of three. Keep the accompaniment under the melody.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Count six eighths first, then feel two groups of three. Keep the accompaniment under the melody.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Count six eighths first, then feel two groups of three. Keep the accompaniment under the melody.

Practise · Silent Night: two large beats

Count six eighths first, then feel two groups of three. Keep the accompaniment under the melody.

Your musical check

Can you tap only the two large beats without losing the shorter notes?

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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7. Holy, Holy, Holy: dotted precision

Count the subdivisions through each dotted rhythm. Do not let the short note arrive early.
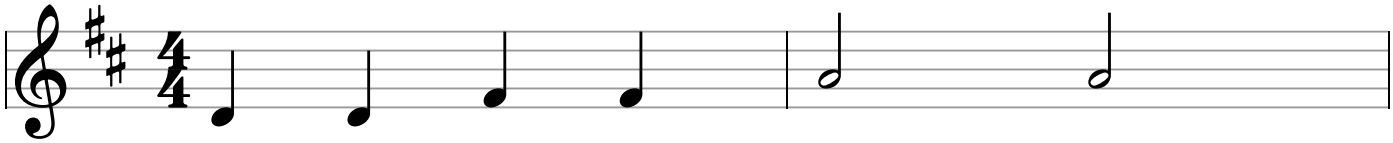
What to listen for

Count the subdivisions through each dotted rhythm. Do not let the short note arrive early.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Count the subdivisions through each dotted rhythm. Do not let the short note arrive early.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Count the subdivisions through each dotted rhythm. Do not let the short note arrive early.

Practise · Holy, Holy, Holy: dotted precision

Count the subdivisions through each dotted rhythm. Do not let the short note arrive early.

Your musical check

Compare the first and second dotted phrases at the same tempo.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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8. Blessed Assurance

Feel three large dotted-quarter beats in each 9/8 bar and place the pickup calmly.

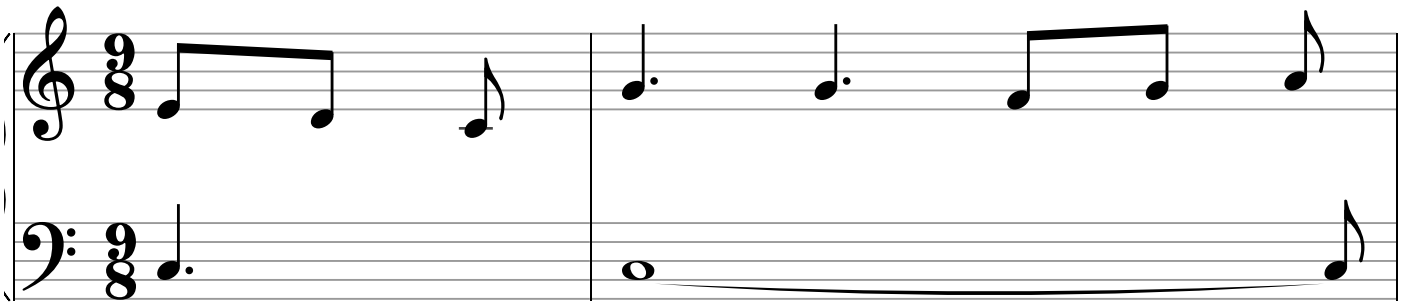
Prepare your recital

Feel three large dotted-quarter beats in each 9/8 bar and place the pickup calmly.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Blessed Assurance

Feel three large dotted-quarter beats in each 9/8 bar and place the pickup calmly.



Opening example · 9/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Feel three large dotted-quarter beats in each 9/8 bar and place the pickup calmly.

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9. Silent Night

Feel two large beats in each 6/8 bar. Place the pickup and dotted rhythms calmly and keep the

shorter notes evenly spaced.

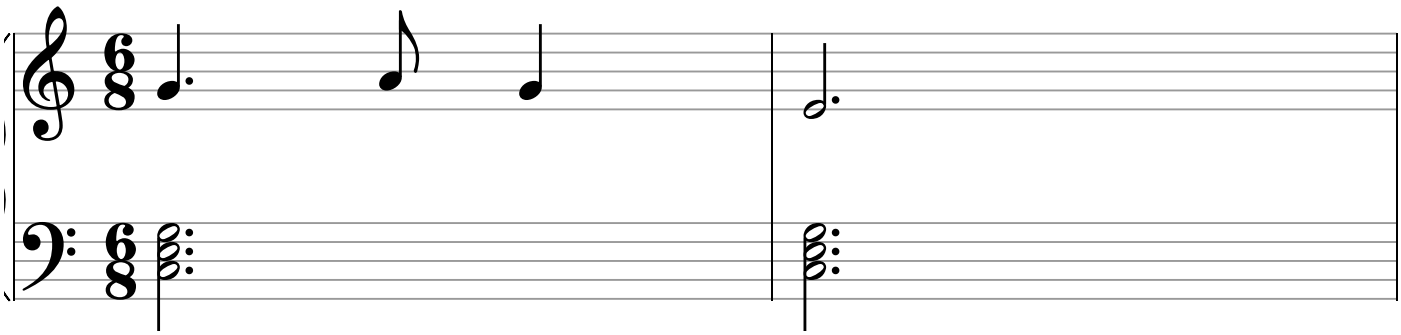
Prepare your recital

Feel two large beats in each 6/8 bar. Place the pickup and dotted rhythms calmly and keep the shorter notes evenly spaced.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Silent Night

Feel two large beats in each 6/8 bar. Place the pickup and dotted rhythms calmly and keep the shorter notes evenly spaced.



Opening example · 6/8 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Feel two large beats in each 6/8 bar. Place the pickup and dotted rhythms calmly and keep the shorter notes evenly spaced.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Use a reliable subdivision beneath changing rhythms.
- ☐ Keep counting when a note begins between beats.
- ☐ Feel 6/8 and 9/8 as groups of three eighths.
- ☐ Distinguish triplets from ordinary eighth notes.
- ☐ Let an offbeat note continue across a strong beat.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, a clear melody, steady pulse and comfortable movement.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
